A Guide for Learning and Playing Japanese Mahjong © 2026 Christopher Yee (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0) For full attributions, third-party content details, and licensing information, see the companion PDF: Back Matter

Setup & Gameplay Reference

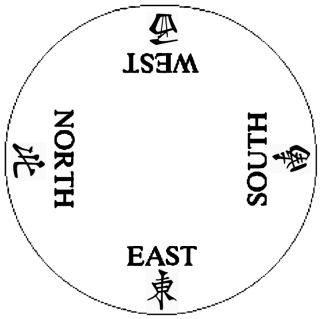
Overview: A standard game of Japanese mahjong is played by four players and is organized into a series of rounds. Each round consists of multiple individual units of play called hands, in which players begin with 13 tiles and take turns drawing and discarding tiles as they attempt to complete a winning hand.

Players may choose the number of rounds, though one or two are most common. In an East–South game (*hanchan*), play consists of the East round followed by the South round, creating a longer game with more hands and opportunities to score. In contrast, an East-only game (*tonpuusen*) ends after the East round is completed, making it a shorter, faster format.

Each hand begins with players building walls of tiles and dealing so that each player has 13 tiles. Since a winning hand consists of 14 tiles, players must either draw their winning tile from the wall or claim it from an opponent's discard.

The objective of the game is to accumulate the most points from winning hands by the end of the game.

Seat Wind: Each player is associated with a directional wind known as the seat wind. East is the starting player. South is sitting to East's right, West is sitting across from East, and North is sitting to East's left. Between hands, the seat winds will change (covered in Dealer Rotation below).



At Game Start:

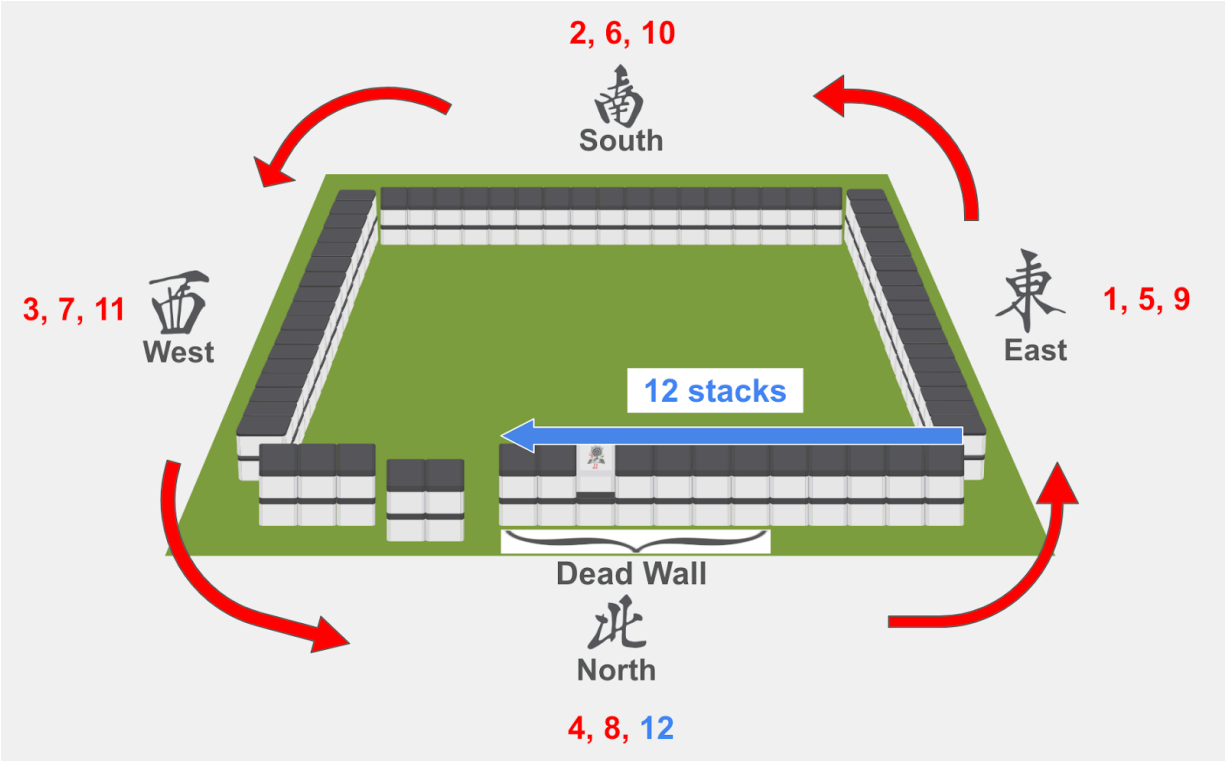
- **Determine Starting Seat Wind:** Shuffle the four wind tiles face-down — east wind, south wind, north wind, and west wind — and have each player pick one. The East player sits first, with the others seated around the table in order.
- **Distribute Point Sticks:** Give each player 25,000 points worth of point sticks if available (see Point Sticks Reference at the back of this packet). Otherwise, scores may be tracked using pen and paper.
- **Position the Wind Indicator:** If a wind indicator is available (shown right), place it with East facing up at the center of the table or to the right of the starting East player. The function of the wind indicator is to indicate the current round of the game. Wherever it is placed, it remains there for the duration of the game.

- **Decide on a Ruleset:** Riichi mahjong can be played in several ways, from casual games with friends to competitive tournament formats. Before starting, players should agree to certain rules. For example:
  • How many rounds to play (e.g., East-only vs. East–South)
  • Whether to include red fives (special bonus tiles)
  Two recommended rulesets — one casual and one competitive — are provided at the end of the *Additional Rules & Supplementary Materials* packet. These lists of detailed rules may look long, but you will gradually become familiar with them as you read through the packets. For now, you only need to focus on the basics. After playing a few hands and getting comfortable with the flow of the game, you can then explore optional rules or decide which variations your group prefers. A blank ruleset template is also included if you want to design your own custom ruleset.

To Begin Each Hand:

1. **Build the Wall:** Shuffle the tiles face-down. Each player builds a wall of face-down tiles, 17 tiles long and 2 tiles high. The walls are pushed together to form a square.

2. **Break the Wall:** East rolls two dice and counts that number of players counterclockwise, starting with themselves. The player thus determined breaks the wall in front of them, by counting from the right the same number of stacks as indicated by the dice. If East's dice roll was 12, the wall is broken as shown in the picture.



The seven tile stacks to the right of the break make up the dead wall. The fourteen tiles of the dead wall are distinct from the rest of the tiles of the wall and serve specific purposes. The dead wall continues around the corner to the next wall, if the end of the wall is reached. The dead wall may be separated from the rest of the wall. The remaining tiles are known as the live wall.

3. _____: The player in front of the dead wall counts three tile stacks into the dead wall from the left and turns the top tile face-up _____. You will fill in the blanks here after learning about dora (bonus tiles) later in the guide.

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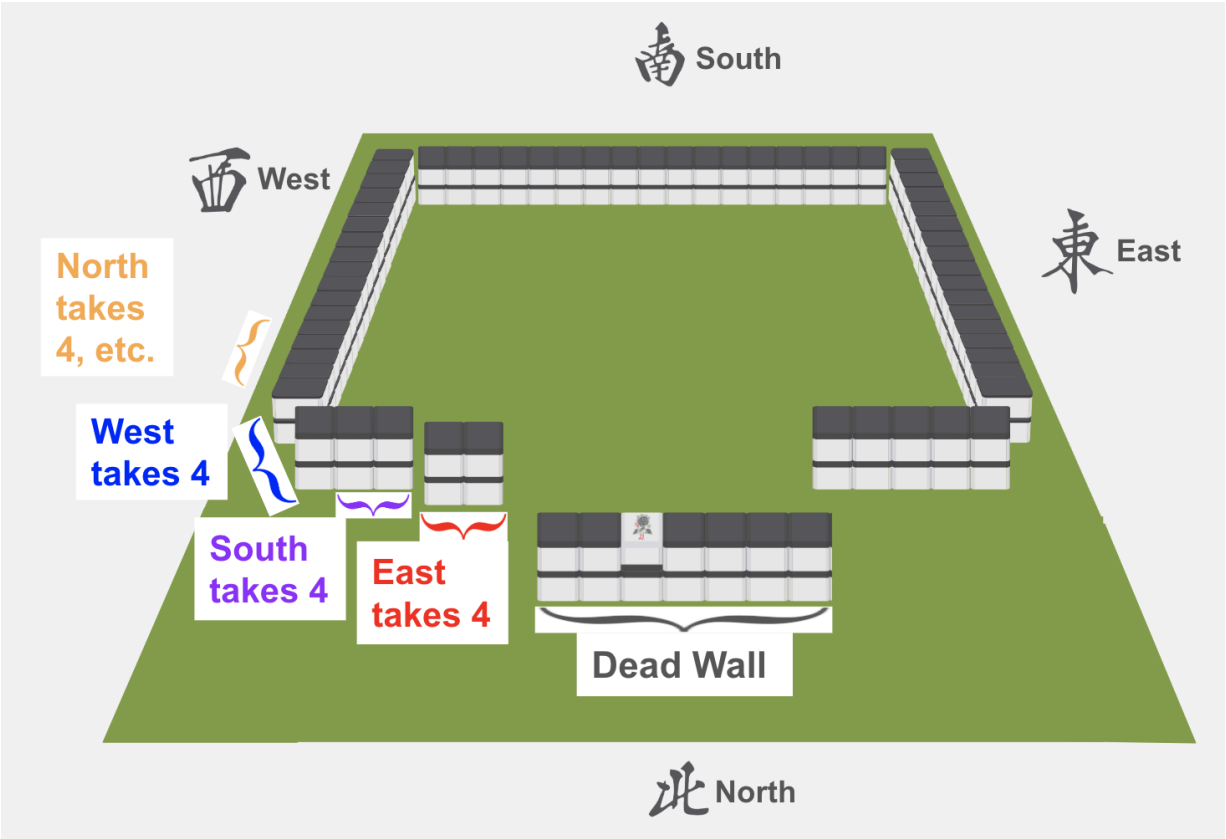
4. **Deal the Tiles:** East takes the first four tiles from the live wall after the original break in the wall. Tiles are taken clockwise along the wall. South takes the next four tiles, West the next four, North the next four, and so on until all players have 12 tiles. East, South, West, and North then each take one tile in order, taking the top tile of a stack, then the bottom tile before moving onto the next stack. Now all players have 13 tiles. Players arrange their tiles upright in front of themselves, so only they can see the faces.



5. **Return the Dice to East:** Place the dice to East's right; this makes it clear to all players which player is the current East. (Other tokens or indicators may be used to mark the current East player if desired.)

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Phases of the Game: Each round consists of at least four hands, during which each player is East in turn. The first hand begins at the start of the game; each subsequent hand begins when the previous hand ends. A hand ends when a player completes a winning hand and declares a win, or when an exhaustive draw occurs (that is, when the tiles in the live wall run out and no player wins after the final discard).

Playing a Hand: Each hand consists of turns taken in <u>counterclockwise</u> order, <u>beginning with East</u>.

(The remaining bullets will be filled in once you learn about the additional actions.)

A player begins their turn by doing one of the following:

- Drawing the next tile from the live wall
-

During their turn, a player may:

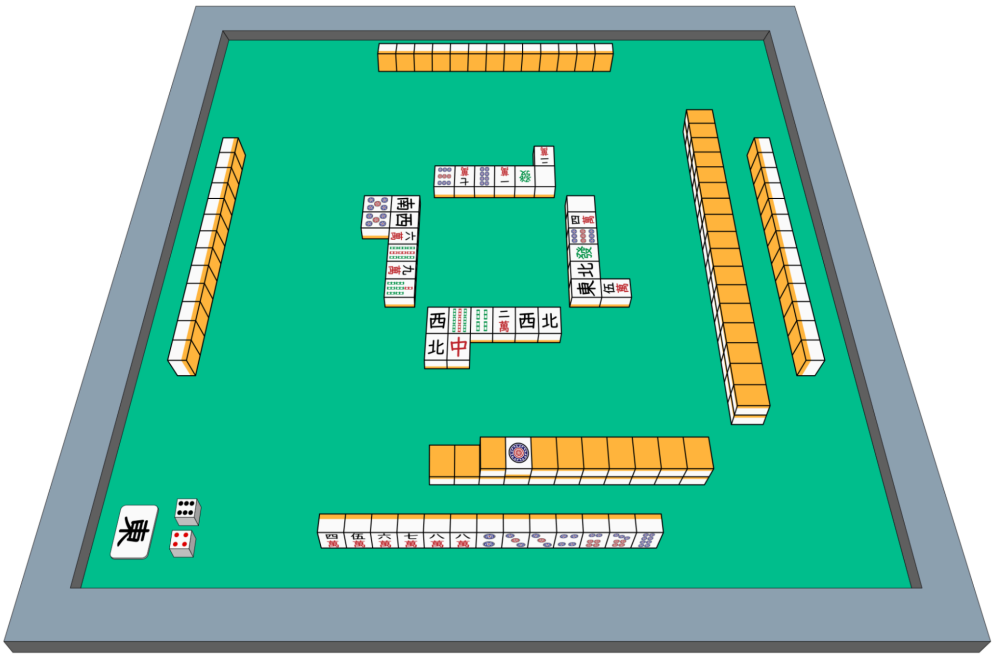
- Declare a win by self-draw
-
-

If a player does not perform any of the available actions on their turn, they must discard a tile from their hand to end their turn.

Any player may claim the most recently discarded tile for a win if it completes their winning hand.

Note: When drawing from the live wall, players take the top tile of a stack first, then the bottom tile before moving onto the next stack.

Handling Tiles: Players are encouraged to draw, discard, and take tiles using the same hand. It is also recommended to keep a drawn tile on top of or to the side of the hand, rather than immediately sorting it in, until the turn is complete. Discards should be arranged neatly in front of each player in rows of six, so it is clear who discarded which tiles and in what order. If necessary, the third row may extend beyond six tiles.



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Dealer Rotation: During the game, East has special scoring privileges and is always regarded as the dealer. At the end of each hand, it is determined whether East remains the dealer or whether the dealer privilege passes to the next player.

East remains East if they win the hand or if they are *tenpai* (one tile away from winning) at the end of an exhaustive draw. If multiple players win, East stays East if they are among the winners. This continuation of the dealer is called a dealer repeat (*renchan*).

Otherwise, the dealer rotates: the player who was South becomes East, West becomes South, North becomes West, and East becomes North — that is, the seat winds rotate counterclockwise.

To rotate the dealer, move the dice from the current East player to the player on their right.

Round Winds and the End of the Game: When the game begins, East is the round wind. When the player who started the game as East becomes East again, after all other players have played at least one hand as East, the game ends in an East-only game.

In an East-South game, play continues to the South round, and South becomes the round wind. Then, when the player who started the game as East becomes East again, the game ends in an East-South game. If additional rounds are played, play continues to the West round and West becomes the round wind, and so on.

When moving into the South round, flip the wind indicator so that it shows the character for South.

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Notes

Note 1: An Explanation for Round Winds

The section Round Winds and the End of the Game stated that when the game begins, East is the round wind, and that when the game proceeds to the South round, South is the round wind, and so on. The round wind is a yaku itself, so if a player's hand has a triplet of the East wind in the East round, for example, their hand has a yaku (refer to pg. 2 of the List of Yaku packet). The round wind is also commonly referred to as the prevalent wind, or prevailing wind.

Note 2: *Agari Yame* and *Tenpai Yame*

If the dealer wins the final hand, a dealer repeat normally occurs and another hand is played with the same seat winds. However, if the dealer also holds the highest score, the game may end immediately. The player who began the game as East does not need to become East again.

Under rulesets that include the variation *agari yame* (win and stop), the dealer may choose to conclude the game upon winning while in first place. In other variations, the dealer may end the game if they are simply in *tenpai* (one tile away from winning) at the conclusion of the final hand and still hold the highest score (*tenpai yame*).

These rule variations are often used in online and casual play but are generally not utilized in standardized tournament or professional settings. Competitive rules generally disallow them because the game's final point totals are meant to be determined by playing out any required dealer repeats and completing the prescribed rounds, rather than letting a single dealer end the match early when leading. This ensures all players have an equal opportunity to influence the final results.

Note 3: Names of the Hands of Each Round

In Riichi mahjong, each hand within a round is labeled with the round wind followed by a number indicating the dealer rotation within that round. For example, the first hand of the East round is called East 1 (東一局). After the first dealer rotation, when South becomes East, the next hand is East 2. When the dealer rotates again, the next hand is East 3, and so on until East 4.

If the dealer (East) wins or remains in tenpai on an exhaustive draw, the same hand number repeats with an added repeat marker (often written as East 1 Repeat 1 / 東一局一本場, East 1 Repeat 2 / 東一局二本場, etc.), indicating additional hands with the same dealer under the same round wind. Once all four players have served as East (completing East 1 through East 4) and no further repeats occur, the East round is complete. The final hand of a round is commonly referred to as "All Last" (*Oorasu* / オーラス). In an East-only game, All Last refers to East 4.

In an East–South game (*hanchan*), once East 4 finishes without a repeat, the round wind shifts to South, and play continues through South 1, South 2, South 3, and South 4 (with repeats allowed as usual). The All Last of a hanchan is South 4. After South 4 (All Last), the overall winner is determined by total points.

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Note 4: Ties

If two or more players finish the game with the same point total, many competitive rulesets treat them as tied. For example, if a tournament game ends with East at 14,000 points, South at 20,000, West at 20,000, and North at 46,000, North takes first place. South and West are treated as tied, typically splitting the ranking points for second and third place, while East receives fourth-place ranking points.

In contrast, many online clients break ties by applying a fixed ordering rule, usually giving priority to whichever player was dealer earlier in the game (that is, whoever first held the East seat). For example, suppose an online game ends with East at 35,000 points, South at 23,000, West at 21,000, and North at 21,000. Because West became dealer before North did, West is awarded third place and North is placed fourth.

Note 5: Starting Points May Vary

Players typically begin with 25,000 points, which is standard for casual and club play. Tournament or professional rules sometimes use 30,000 starting points and may include placement bonuses (*uma*). Other values, such as 20,000–27,000, are occasionally used in home or local variations.

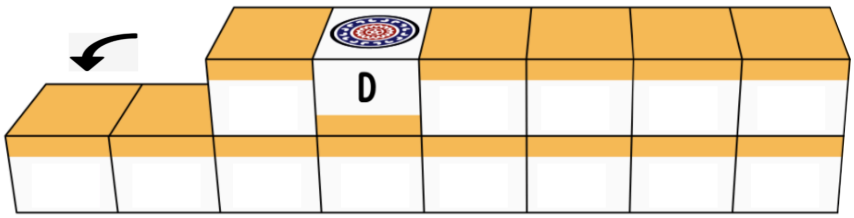
Note 6: Additional Methods for Starting Seat Winds

In addition to the primary method described above, players may use simplified alternatives. Some traditional seating procedures involve additional tiles and multiple dice rolls to determine drawing order, but many groups use shorter methods such as the following.

- Rolling dice for seats: Each player rolls a pair of dice. The player with the highest total becomes East (the dealer). The remaining players are then assigned the South, West, and North seats in counterclockwise order, typically based on the next highest rolls.
- Drawing wind tiles with dice-determined order: Shuffle the four wind tiles face-down and have players draw them to determine their seat winds. A dice roll may first be used to determine the order in which players draw (for example, to decide who draws first, second, third, and fourth).

Note 7: Putting Down the Replacement Tile

In Step 2 (Break the Wall), a commonly used practice is for the player in front of the dead wall to place the top left tile of the dead wall to the immediate left of it, so that the wall begins with two single tiles followed by six tile stacks. This is in order to decrease the risk of knocking down and revealing the first replacement tile. This repositioning of the first replacement tile can be done right after the player breaks the wall.



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Note 8: Keeping the Dead Wall and Live Wall Together

Step 2 (Break the Wall) stated the dead wall may be separated from the live wall to form an independent section. However, many competitive rulesets instruct players to keep the dead wall and live wall physically intact. The dead wall is conceptually maintained as always containing 14 tiles, and players simply count tiles to preserve its size and order. Physically shifting tiles is often avoided to reduce the risk of accidental exposure or disruption of the wall's structure.

Note 9: East Should Actually Take 14 Tiles at the Start of a Hand

Players were instructed to end up with 13 tiles in Step 4 (Deal the Tiles) for simplicity. However, once players are comfortable with the deal, they should adopt the following conventional method used in official rulebooks to expedite the start of the hand:

- After each player has 12 tiles, East takes two tiles: the top tiles from the first and third stacks in the wall. South, West, and North then each take one tile in order. This procedure effectively gives East the 14th tile they would have drawn at the start of play, allowing them more time to examine their complete 14-tile starting hand before making their first discard.

Note 10: Pushing Walls Forward to Facilitate Drawing

Players are encouraged to adjust their walls to make drawing tiles quicker and smoother for everyone. Care should be taken to avoid accidentally revealing tiles when doing so.

At the start of a hand, all players may push their walls slightly forward, often positioning the right side a bit farther forward than the left. As the hand progresses and the live wall is depleted, players may continue moving their walls forward or slightly to the right to maintain easy access for the next draw.

Note 11: A Second Dice Roll

In Step 2 (Break the Wall), some rule variations allow the player determined by the initial dice roll to roll again. The second roll may be used to determine the exact position of the break within that player's wall.

In other variations, the second roll determines a different player whose wall will be broken, using the same counterclockwise counting procedure originally used by East. That player then breaks the wall in front of them by counting from the right the number of stacks indicated by the second roll.

These two-roll methods introduce additional randomness but deviate from standard Riichi rules, which use only a single dice roll.

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Note 12: A Winning Hand May Contain More Than 14 Tiles

In the Overview, it was asserted that a winning hand consists of 14 tiles. However, if a player forms one or more quadruplets and later wins, the completed hand will contain more than 14 tiles.

For example, suppose a player has the following 13-tile starting hand:

They draw 1-man on their turn and may form 1111-man as a special set. Although this is covered in the Introduction to Tile Calls packet, the following shows a simplified version of the procedure: the player displays the set 1111-man on the table, draws one tile from the dead wall, and discards one tile from their hand.

The net result is that their hand has 14 tiles after the discard: with 13 tiles in hand to start, it increases to 14 when they draw 1-man, remains at 14 when they form 1111-man (since 1111-man is still considered part of their hand), increases to 15 when they draw from the dead wall, and returns to 14 when they discard.

The player now has one completed set — the quadruplet 1111-man — and 10 remaining tiles (467-man, 336-sou, 2459-pin) with which to make three sets and a pair to win. Suppose the player develops the hand to 567-man, 333-sou, 4569-pin, which contains three sets, with the remaining tile 9-pin waiting to form a pair to win. If the hand wins, it will consist of 15 tiles: 4 from the quadruplet, 9 from the other three sets, and 2 from the pair.

Each quadruplet increases the physical tile count of the completed hand by one. It is possible to form four quadruplets, increasing the hand size to 17 tiles, and 18 upon winning. Incidentally, winning with four quadruplets earns the yakuman Four Quads (*Suukantsu*), which is often cited as the rarest standard winning hand in Japanese mahjong, occurring roughly once in every 500,000 winning hands.

Note 13: On East-South-West-North Ordering

You may notice that the counterclockwise turn order East–South–West–North does not correlate with the directions of a compass, as going counterclockwise on a compass gives East–North–West–South. Mahjong originated in China during the mid-to-late 19th century (around the Qing Dynasty) before spreading across East Asia and beyond. Although there is no definitive explanation for this ordering, it is often thought to reflect traditional Chinese cosmological or seasonal sequencing. Counterclockwise rotation was also common in traditional East Asian games of the time, and this convention continues in many such games today.

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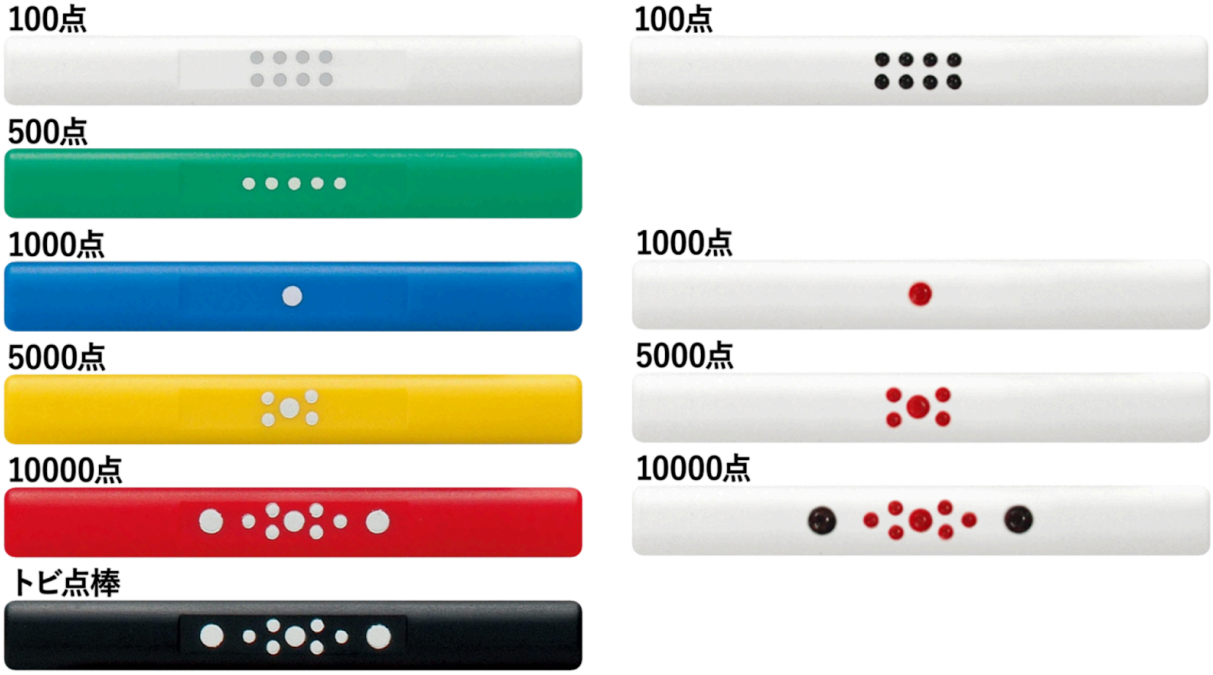
Point Sticks Reference



「点棒」Tenbou is the Japanese word for the physical sticks that players use to keep track of their score, with「点」ten meaning point(s) and「棒」bou meaning stick.
「トビ」Tobi is an optional rule which can allow play to continue if a player falls below zero points, for which the black sticks shown above may be used.

With **multi-colored** point sticks and each player starting at 25,000 points, it is recommended to give each player at the start of the game:	With **white-colored** point sticks and each player starting at 25,000 points, it is recommended to give each player at the start of the game:
1 × 10,000-point stick (red) 2 × 5,000-point sticks (yellow) 4 × 1,000-point sticks (blue) 1 × 500-point stick (green) 5 × 100-point sticks (white)	1 × 10,000-point stick 2 × 5,000-point sticks 4 × 1,000-point sticks 10 × 100-point sticks

Etiquette Tips:

- To streamline payment of a winning hand, players should minimize the number of sticks exchanged whenever possible.
  - Example 1: When a player wins a 3900 point hand by ron, the player who discarded the winning tile can give the winner one 5000-point stick, and the winner can give back one 1000-point stick and one 100-point stick in return.
  - Example 2: If a player needs to pay 4000 points, they can give a 5000-point stick to the winner, and the winner can give back a 1000-point stick.
- The correct amount of point sticks should be placed in the play area to let all players see the exchange clearly.
- Players should retain at least one 1000-point stick at all times for riichi whenever possible. If a player runs out of 1000-point sticks, they should exchange a 5000- or 10000-point stick for change from another player, which is best done before the next shuffle. However, if necessary, the player should ask before declaring riichi.

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